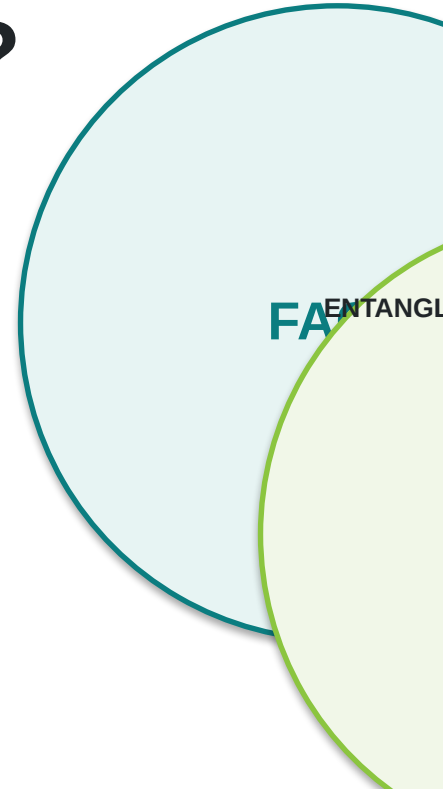


FACT / VALUE

What makes a society successful?

An economy grows. A government survives. An empire expands.



Hilary Putnam : The Entanglement of Fact and Value

Social science explains how societies work

1

POINT 1

Economics investigates production, wages, prices, and demand. Political science investigates power, cooperation, conflict, and institutions. History investigates

2

POINT 2

3

An economy grows. Are people better off?

5%

OUTPUT GROWTH



CONDITION 1

Median purchasing power remains unchanged.



CONDITION 2

Working hours increase.



CONDITION 3

Preventable illness becomes more common.

Imagine a country where:

“Progress” requires a standard

Different standards bring different features into view:

1

POINT 1

Production: How much does the economy produce?

2

POINT 2

Living standards: What can ordinary people afford?

3

POINT 3

Well-being: How healthy, secure, and fulfilled are people?

4

POINT 4

Freedom: What meaningful choices are available?

A useful distinction can become a sweeping c

1

DESCRIPTION

Descriptive claims: "Average working hours increased"

2

EVALUATION

Evaluative claims: "These working c

Equal income can conceal unequal opportunities

1

SIDE A

One can travel and work without additional assistance

2

SIDE B

The other needs expensive mobility support

A better question can reveal overlooked factors

Amartya Sen proposes examining people's capabilities: their actual opportunities to do and be things that they value.



1

Mobility and accessibility.



2

Nutrition and shelter.



3

Participation.

Satisfaction can be an incomplete measure

People can adapt to difficult circumstances and lower their expectations.

1

2

Reported satisfaction tells us something important. It can coexist with restricted opportunities. Whether it adequately

A deeply unequal allocation can be efficient

99

1

ASSUMPTION 1

The supply is fixed.

2

ASSUMPTION 2

Each person prefers having more.

3

Neither c

Helping either person requires taking something from the other.

Efficiency answers a limited question

1

99 / 1

Pareto efficient



2

50 / 50

Pareto efficient



The criterion does not tell us which distribution is fair

Can we criticize our measures of success?

Suppose a welfare measure systematically overlooks serious, avoidable suffering

1

POINT 1

It may omit conditions central to people's lives

2

POINT 2

It may treat relevantly different circumstances as equivalent

3

It may ignore upward outcomes

A government can survive through different m

A political model might explain stability through:

1

POINT 1

Reliable taxation.

2

POINT 2

Effective admini

3

POINT 3

Cooperation among powerful groups.

4

POINT 4

Public support—or effec

Public order needs interpretation

Imagine that demonstrations sharply decline.

1

POINT 1

Citizens are more satisfied.

2

POINT 2

Grievances have been addressed.

3

POINT 3

Organizing has become dangerous.

4

POINT 4

People believe protest is futile.

Power, acceptance, and justification differ

1

POWER

The government secures obedience.

How effective

2

BELIEF

Citizens believe it has a right to rule.

What do ci

3

JUSTIFICATION

It has a right to rule.

Is its auth

Evidence for one claim does not automatically establish the others

Institutions embody choices that remain open to c

Property rules, voting procedures, and tax systems organize whose claims receive reco

1

POINT 1

How did these arrangements emerge?

2

POINT 2

What consequences do they produce? What reasons s

3

Historical questions shape what becomes vis

1

SIDE A

Consider a history of an empire. A focus on administration directs attention to

2

SIDE B

Frederick Douglass challenged an interpretation

1

SIDE A

2

SIDE B

...y, Douglass described people mistaking enslaved people's playing that, in his experience, singing

Historical judgment requires discipline

Taking people's experiences seriously requires careful evidence.

1

POINT 1

Read sources in their historical context.

2

POINT 2

Investigate disagreements and

3

POINT 3

Examine evidence that challenges your interpretation.

4

POINT 4

Separate explaining an action

Our judgments about the past shape future go

Imagine evaluating a past government.

1

2

success means survival, we may emphasize preserving the public security, we investigate success in order to improve, we

Interaction alone does not prove entanglement

1

SIDE A

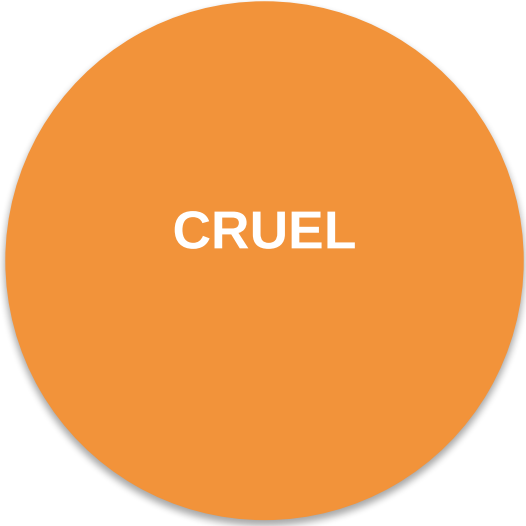
Values influence research questions and institutions.

2

SIDE B

Evidence can change

Some concepts describe and evaluate together

A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the word CRUEL in white capital letters.

CRUEL

A large blue circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the word HONEST in white capital letters.

HONEST

A large green circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the word COURAGEOUS in white capital letters.

COURAGEOUS

Philosophers call these thick ethical concepts. They characterize conduct while also carrying evaluative weight.

This is a central question in Putnam's argument. The reading...

What makes an action cruel?

Imagine a teacher repeatedly ridiculing a struggling student.

1

POINT 1

What suffering or humiliation occurred?

2

POINT 2

What did the teacher do?

3

POINT 3

How vulnerable was the student?

4

POINT 4

What reasons, if any, justify the action?

Putnam challenges the proposed separation

1

SIDE A

Can the neutral description identify everything relevant to identity such as “gratuitous” or “humor”?

2

SIDE B

Scientific inquiry also depends on standard

Scientists assess explanations using:

1

POINT 1

Fit with evidence.

2

POINT 2

Coherence

3

POINT 3

Explanatory power.

4

POINT 4

Simplicity, where a

Disagreement does not automatically defeat rational judgment

Researchers can disagree about:

1

POINT 1

Which explanation is more adequate.

2

POINT 2

Whether an assumption is reasonable.

3

How to weigh

The strongest objection distinguishes kinds of

1

SIDE A

2

SIDE B

ence needing standards does not automatically establish moral truth. Putnam must explain why ethical jud

Entanglement does not settle every moral ques

Putnam's challenge does not establish that:

1

POINT 1

Every factual statement is a moral judgment.

2

POINT 2

Every sincere evaluation

3

POINT 3

Economic growth automatically creates an obligation.

4

POINT 4

One political system follows uni

Evaluative standards can themselves face criticism

Suppose we call a policy fair because everyone receives the same payment.

1

POINT 1

Does equal payment address substantially different needs?

2

POINT 2

Does the rule serve its purpose?

3

POINT 3

Can its justification survive relevant counterexamples?

4

POINT 4

What evidence would make us change our mind?

The larger issue is the reach of reason

The stakes extend across disciplines:

1

POINT 1

Economics: Can we justify what counts as welfare?

2

POINT 2

Politics: Can we assess authority?

3

POINT 3

History: Can we defend judgments about progress and failure?

4

POINT 4

Science: How do standards of good?

Why read Putnam?

**HILARY
PUTNAM**

**The Entanglement
of Fact and Value**

2002 · Chapter 2 · pp. 28-45



QUESTION 1

Can understanding a human situation require



QUESTION 2

Can value judgments be rationally



QUESTION 3

What would objectivity require if inquiry in

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